The Better Beast

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/58930315.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Grizzlor (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Original Scorpani Character

Additional Tags:
Hurt Adora (She-Ra), Adora Needs a Hug (She-Ra), Adora Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Body Horror, Brutality, Mutilation, Murder, Minor Character Death, War, BAMF Adora, Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Oblivious Adora (She-Ra), Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), Catra Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Catra is Bad at Feelings (She-Ra), Adora is Bad at Feelings (She-Ra), Glimmer Needs a Hug (She-Ra), Bow Is The Ultimate Moral Compass, Morally Grey Glimmer, Grizzlor Is Awful, Sadism, Cannibalism, Feral Behavior, Wolverine AU, Implied/Referenced Sexual Assault, Not Beta Read

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Part 5 of She-Ra Wolverine AU

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by Utter_Immolation

Summary

The Wolverine had a fearsome reputation, but it could not go unchallenged for long.

Or

Enter: Grizzlor

Or

Adora meets her match.

The sound of explosions was nothing new in the kingdom of Dryl. Or was it *former* kingdom? After all, these days the Horde flag flapped ominously in the mountain winds and the Horde did not have kingdoms under its rule, only territories. Protectorates if one was being generous. Servants if one was not.

Whatever they were now considered, whatever the divisive opinions of the populace, it didn't matter to Adora, not right now. Not as the minecart she was being mauled in smashed through tunnel barricade after barricade like so much paper. Not as she wrestled against the curved claws threading their way into her intestines. Not as a drooling, stench-filled mouth filled with jagged, yellowed fangs inched closer and closer to her throat.

Not as darkness exploded into light, and the cart and its inhabitants careened through the final barricade and were launched out of the mountainside into empty air.

Two days earlier:

“You're telling me you didn't even have a garrison?!”

“We didn't need one! We had Entrapta!”

“Well, that turned out well, didn't it?”

“The *Rebellion* is not in the habit of *enforcing* their allies' cooperation!”

“And the *Horde* gives no shits about that!”

“Oh, *you'd* know—”

Adora wondered, idly, if she lit a cigar in here, would anyone notice.

Glancing at the arguing forms of Catra and Glimmer, both red in face and one bad taste remark from trying to claw the other's eyes out, she doubted it.

On paper, it was a good idea. Put the former Horde soldier on the same command-level as the Princess of Brightmoon. Not only did it allow the Rebellion to utilize Catra's devious mind and bring some actual military strategy to bear (Adora respected Angella, but sometimes she wondered just who she had teaching her daughter how to wage war) but it would be a symbol to all: anyone could rise through the ranks. All opinions were to be considered. The monarchy was far more open-minded than they may appear. It was an inspiring and clever move on the Immortal Queen's part.

On paper.

Adora would say Catra and Glimmer fought like cats and dogs, but as something not unlike a dog herself (she thinks, she should really ask Light Hope about that) she knew that unless her memory was even more messed up than she suspected, she and Catra had never fought each other as viciously as this.

Oh sure, their arguments sometimes got physical, even now, but the sheer caustic vitriol spat back and forth between the hybrid and the Princess made the fights between the Horde-raised look like tame, childish slap fights.

When Catra suggested something, Glimmer was bound to disagree. When Glimmer suggested something, Catra was bound to return the favor, only with an insult. Glimmer in turn gave as good as she got and before long, the arguments were only *barely* about the matter at hand, just enough to keep Angella's patience and tolerance from completely evaporating. Of course, when the Queen was unable to sit in on their strategy meetings, the bets were off and things got *nasty* and *quick* .

“Want to say that again, Princess?!”

“What, those giant ears stop working?”

“I'll rip those little nubs of yours *right off, you* —”

Adora glanced about. Most of the Alliance wasn't here, save Frosta who looked way too entertained and enthusiastic at the possibility

of the fight unfolding before her eyes becoming physical. The only other people were a handful of Brightmoon guards and the towering scorpani scout who had given the report that caused this ruckus in the first place. All looked steadily more uncomfortable and awkward even as their heads ping-ponged back and forth as they followed the verbal barrage.

She looked to her side, catching Swift Wind's eye. He took the hint and rose from where he'd been gnawing lazily at a bone, giving a stretch and shake before releasing a long, loud and haunting howl. Adora marvels at the intuitive intonations of his chord. *Not an emergency. Just fun. Pay attention to me.*

(She wonders if this understanding of her Pack comes down to their magical connection or if she has always just…been able to understand the nuances of the animal world. Has she always been able to simply smell and hear and *get* those subtle shifts of scent and sound and have them translate into a discernible message? How much of it is She-Ra and how much of it is Adora? And if the latter, what does that even mean anymore?)

Pleased with the silence his howl has brought about, Swift Wind turns to Adora with an eager chuff and gives a happy pant as she scratches his ears, partly in thanks and partly to settle her own nerves.

"Well," she coughs awkwardly. "Given that we're being probed at the front and back—"

(Several people coughed.)

“—how about we send a small unit?”

“So my first suggestion?” Catra snarked, glowering at Glimmer.

Glimmer bared her teeth back. “We're stretched *too thin* . We can't afford to send a squad of Princesses—”

“Who said anything about Princesses?” Adora interjects. “I meant me.”

If she thought this was going to be a simple and elegant suggestion, she was wrong. Both commanders exploded in protest.

“Don't be a dumbass—”

“We need you—”

“—can't go alone—”

“—symbol of the Rebellion—”

"—no idea what you'll find—"

"—could be dangerous —"

Adora whistled. "Hey! I know the risks. But I'm the best choice and we all *know* that."

Both opened their mouths again, but Adora barreled on, counting off her points on her fingers.

"I can move fast, I know how to be stealthy, I can take anything they throw at me, one magical person is less noticeable than a bunch of royals, we need to hold the line at the Woods, Swift Wind can coordinate the Pack in my absence and most importantly, Dryl's materials coupled with Entrapta's brain means if we don't start cutting them off and sabotaging their sources, their bot ranks and tech are going to swell past anything we can counter, even with more volunteers. We kicked the Horde in the balls but we *can't* afford a war of attrition. Nor," she let a bit of a growl slip into her tone as she glared at her technical superiors, "can we afford to squabble like cadets."

She took a deep breath, pushing away the creature in her hindbrain that whispered for a fight, that wanted to dominate, prove its superiority and instead snapped a salute. "So. Permission to undertake a recon and sabotage mission to Dryl? Ma'ams."

It wasn't that Glimmer didn't respect Catra.

She did. Really! The hybrid, for all her faults, was…she was smart. Very smart, smarter than anyone would think, given how she tended to carry herself, sort of like Adora. Unlike Adora, Catra *knew* she was smart, and had no problem rubbing it in people's faces (especially after someone underestimated her).

And it was so infuriating! She never took anything seriously so how was Glimmer supposed to just know when Catra actually knew what she was doing! Half the time Catra was as likely to crack a joke as she was to actually contribute to the conversation. They were at war! They didn't have time for cracking stupid puns, they needed to get to the point!

Not to mention that every order Glimmer made, Catra countered it. Glimmer wanted to attack, Catra wanted to scout. Glimmer wanted to expand pike training, Catra argued that spears were better. Glimmer wanted to split their forces and confront the Horde where they poked their spiky heads, Catra suggested sacrificing one village to save another. And Adora tended to agree with her! Oh, sure, she tried to pretend otherwise, to be a neutral party, but anyone with eyes saw that her instincts and opinions tended to align with Catra. And to make it even worse—if Adora suggested the same thing Glimmer did, Catra actually paid attention. Sometimes she even compromised!

And…okay. Maybe Glimmer didn't help with her own reactions. And maybe, with hindsight, Glimmer could see that Catra's ideas ("corrections", she called them) occasionally had merit. But…but

come on! Glimmer had been here first! Sure they were “equals”, but a Glimmer was still here first! Her words had weight!

“I don't think that's how it works,” Bow mused.

“Bow!”

He raised his hands placatingly. “I'm just saying, your mom made Catra a commander specifically to bring in more divisive opinions. Having her daughter have “seniority” sort of defeats the point. And besides do you really want your co-commander to be a yes-woman?”

“Yes.”

“Glimmer…”

“Ugh! *Fine* . I'll admit that Catra has some…occasional good points. Just…does she have to be such a brat about it?”

“Yes.”

The new voice made the longtime friends jump and screech in panic. Catra rolled her eyes as she climbed through Glimmer's

window. “And this, Sparkles, is why I suggested mandatory situational awareness training.”

Glimmer recovered the quickest. “My awareness is fine!”

“Uh-huh,” Catra said, unconvinced. “That may be fine for someone who can teleport in and out of danger but in the Horde—”

“Let me guess: they hang you by your toes?”

“Nah,” Catra said with deliberate calm. “They beat you, starve you and make you run it all over.”

Glimmer wasn't an unempathetic person. But she could be competitive, especially about matters she should *really* back down from. “This isn't the Horde, though!”

“Clearly.”

“Do you even *want* to fight them, because you sure seem to—!”

“ENOUGH!”

The women stopped, blinking at Bow in surprise. Glimmer has heard Bow lose his temper before, though it was such a rare occurrence, she couldn't even recall the last time it occured. Catra however had never seen it happen, and the sound and sight of the normally docile archer exploding was enough to leave the feline hybrid slack-jawed.

As soon as he exploded, the archer's temper receeded and he slumped back into his chair with an exhausted sigh. “Sorry, sorry, I just…haven't been sleeping.”

Catra and Glimmer locked eyes and came to a silent truce. The feline stretched out on a nearby chaise with deliberate calm but her face was softer. Even the former Force Captain wasn't impervious to Bow's natural charm. “Entrapta?”

Bow nodded wearily. “Her encryptions are top notch and getting an intact comms unit is a problem—Horde troops have gotten really good at destroying their tech. But as it is, we've gotten rumors and whispers in the soup about a big initiative that apparently has Entrapta's, and therefore Hordak's, direct supervision and attention: something called the Weapon X Project.”

Catra blinked. “Sounds ominous.”

“And dangerous,” Glimmer grimly noted. “We need to get more info.”

Catra barely refrained from saying something snarky. “Any ideas?”

Glimmer grinned. “Simple. We ask the Horde.”

Now both Catra and Bow were looking at her. “And…” Bow said slowly. “How do we do that?”

“Rama went with Adora but the rest of the Pack is here.” Glimmer looked at Catra. “Up for a hunt tomorrow?”

Catra's fangs gleamed in the light. “Always.”

The mountain paths of Dryl were a bit too exposed for her tastes, but it was always nice to stretch her legs and the clean, cool breeze carried a plethora of scents that Adora spent much too much time sniffing at. She could smell everything, from the distant whiff of smoke and burning coal from the capital and the various mines dotted about to the crisp, icy snow from the distant northern peaks that bled into the Kingdom of Snows border.

Behind her Rama was chatting to the Scorpani scout, Birch, whose large frame belied his easy, quiet movements.

“So you're from the region?”

“Yep. My family owned a jewelry shop in the capital, but we closed it when the Horde rolled in. It's probably been smashed and ransacked by now.”

“Huh. I kind of thought the Scorpani supported the Horde.”

“Heh, that's what they want you to think. I was still a hatchling when my parents fled the Fright Zone, but I've heard the stories. A lot of Scorpani had been leaving the Kingdom even before Hordak took over—the old king was hardly popular. But a lot of smart people saw the writing on the wall once the king “abdicated”. The loyalists were being executed left and right, and even those who hated him realized real quick that they had to either leave or get ready for them and their children to get drafted.”

“So they ran?”

“Yep. Carried me and my siblings over the mountains. It was hard but they were lucky; the Horde had a harder time locking down the border than the ports, at least in the beginning.”

Adora frowned, turning towards the duo. “Are they still in Dryl now? Do we need to rescue them?”

“No, no we were lucky. My sister is a sailor, and has a small house near the far port. When the Horde rolled into the capital, we were all visiting and she and her crew got them and several others out of the kingdom.” Birch's face shadowed. “Others weren't so fortunate. One day we were Drylians. The next, Horde slaves.”

“We'll save them,” Adora said firmly. “You have my—”

She freezes. Sniffs.

“Boss?” Rama said lowly, fur shimmering. Birch stiffened, stinger rising into a ready position.

Adora tilted her head into the wind. Threaded within the air wafting through the mountain, intertwined with stone and water and sap, is something metallic, something cloying, something familiar—

Adora's eyes snap open. “Let's move. Now.”

“Ma'am?” Birch inquired warily but Adora was already moving, charging down the mountain trails, down rocky paths, over a small stream, and through a copse of trees to find—

She slowly walks through the destroyed small clearing, through churned mud turned brackish with crimson and kneels beside the shredded remains of a Rebellion scout, gently closing their wide

and terrified eyes. Her own don't stop moving, noting every overturned pot and shredded tent, the still smoldering embers of a fire, the arrows embedded in trees and covered in blood, the knives covered in gore and the broken bodies scattered about, entrails and limbs and heads rained around and already calling to flies.

Behind her she absently hears Birch and Rama slam into the clearing and a moment later Birch's massive frame lurches away, the sound and scent of sick coming a moment later. Rama pads beside her. “Horde ambush?” She asks grimly.

Adora stands, taking in the scene, various minor details poking at and nigging at her brain, forming a picture. “Maybe…but.” She sniffs the air. “No ozone. No blaster marks. Not enough scents.” She scans the various piles and streaks of viscera. “Four Rebels. Five scents.”

She glances at the fire, the small pot overturned and surrounded by a half dried puddle, a half-wrapped bundle of food soaked in gore. “They were getting ready for lunch. Something—someone—came at them, quick. But not too quickly that they couldn't grab weapons.”

She scans the thin mud and dirt, upturned and messy, staring at the patterns, the various clumps. Her brain slots things into place and she rattles them off. “They got close enough where the Rebels didn't see them coming, but then they just strolled in. A friendly? No, the Rebels got alarmed and started scrambling. Someone had a bow, they stood…they warned off the intruder. The intruder slowed down, kept walking. They weren't wary. They were…swaggering. They were having fun.”

Rama huffed in comprehension. “They were hunting.”

Adora nods absently. “They were big,” she notes, pale blue eyes trailing over the crushed green leaves on the ground and the branches surrounding the clearing.. “Easily over six feet. They came, they were warned…” She kneels beside a clump of dust and dirt and a bloody, broken arrow shaft. “They got shot. They didn't bother dodging or maybe couldn't. Steps are steady…they didn't care. Arrow impacted, drew blood…they pulled it, didn't give a shit as to how. Shaft broke, they dropped it, kept walking. Arrow head a moment later, dug it out.”

She picks up said arrow head, sniffed and then licked it. “Heady. Lots of protein. Enjoys a lot of meat, carnivorous, big, traces of fur…” She spat out said strands. “Hybrid.”

Adora stares at the ground then the rest of the campsite again. “They weren't bleeding too much. They either bandaged extremely quickly…or they heal fast. Arrow hit a deeper vein but didn't continue to drip. They leapt…” She checks the distance. “Eight feet forward, easy. It was quick. They hit the nearest Rebel, knocked them down. Archer shot, missed. Others jumped them, they knocked aside or threw them. They were strong, only needed one hand.”

“The Intruder tore the poor sod apart. Possible hand weapons but most likely claws. Big. Much bigger than Catra's, almost as sharp. At least…three inches? They got shot again. They didn't stop. Someone jumped on their back, stabbed them, and they still didn't stop. They could have finished the job quickly but…they

didn't want to. They wanted their victim to suffer. They were having fun.”

Adora took a shuddering breath. “They moved quickly. At least one Rebel died fast but the other two…One tried to run. They were knocked down and…and they got their leg ripped off. But he didn't stay to finish, not right away. He incapacitated the last Rebel then went back to the legless one and…tortured them.”

“Why?” Birch chokes, trembling at the edge of the clearing. “ *Why* ?”

“They're a sadist,” Rama rumbles disgustingly, fur glimmering with magical power. “This…this was all a game to them. A cat with a mouse.”

Adora made another circuit, stopping by a body with certain markings, the likes of which made memories rise in the back of her head, the type half-forgotten and red-tinged. “They drew out the last two deaths, tore them apart…but this one died quickly. And they went back and…” She swallows harshly. “Ate part of them. Part of the arms, legs. The entire heart.”

Rama snarled. Birch gagged.

Adora leaned back on her hutches, mind whirling. There was something more at play here. The mission had changed. This was

no longer simply a matter of espionage and sabotage. This was no longer a matter of two forces being pit against each other.

There was a monster here. And someone needed to take care of it.

“Birch. Go back to the skiff and fall back to base, as quick as you can. Rama and I will continue the mission.”

The Scorpani startled. “But…Captain!”

“That's an order, Private!” Rama barked. Her eyes met Adora's, a grim understanding within them. This was no longer a mission. This was a hunt. “Someone needs to get back to the Rebellion and report about what happened here.”

Birch's face was still tinged with green but he still bravely stepped forward, pincers clenched. “No Captain! You can't go alone! A-and I want in! They killed my squad!”

Adora stood and reached up, gripping the Scorpani by his spiky shoulder. His carapace was vibrant but somewhat orange and had a bit of give. He was young, having not yet hit his prime, barely out of his teenage years, still growing into his shell. She would not see him killed in this hunt, not by this Beast. “And right now the best way to honor them is to go back and not let their deaths be in vain. The Rebellion needs people like you to survive. Carry their

names back, grieve and prepare yourself for future battles. You do the living. Let me do the killing.”

Birch shook like his namesake in a storm before finally going limp in broken acceptance. “Can—can we bury them first?” He tentatively broached, voice wet with grief. “I don—I don't want to just…leave them here.”

No. It's dangerous for them to linger. They needed to get moving. Messing with the scene was a red flag to anyone who backtracked to the area that more Rebels were in the area. They could lose the element of surprise.

“Yes,” Adora responds, the sword on her wrist shifting into a gold and crystal shovel with a flash of light.

It's grim work. Adora has Birch and Rama dig the hole while she gathers the…parts, doing her best to match the various bits with their owners, wrapping each body in the torn and bloodsoaked bedrolls and tying them off the best she can with the tattered remains of the tent.

Dusk has fallen by the time they lower the wrapped forms into the roughshod grave. Birch quietly weeps as Adora and Rama refill the hole, patting the earth down. “From stone, to stone,” he gave a shuddering prayer, pincers clenching. “I'm sorry guys. I'll see the Horde destroyed. I swear on my shell.”

The trio stands in silence for several moments before Adora reluctantly breaks the silence. “Alright, Birch, get going. Rama, watch his back, then meet me down by the capitol. I'm going to do some recon—”

The wind shifts. Adora and Rama freeze.

“Captain?”

“Birch, run.”

“Wh—”

“RUN!”

The scent of blood and drool. The faintest scrape of claw on stone. Adora starts to turn, claws sliding free, the sword emerging in her hand in a flash of light.

“FOR THE HONOR OF GRAYS—URRK!”

A massive blur tries to slide past her, a glinting claw piercing flesh and sliding across her ribs, slitting a lung, carving up—

Her own claws lash out, ripping up and under a massive sternum, popping the heart like a bloody piñata.

The Beast falters but alarmingly, does not fall. Adora can feel the flesh under her hand shift, push, *heal* , inhumanly strong muscle forcibly working to shove her claws out, rob her of her advantage. She buries her other set of claws into the enormous arm trying to burrow into her large intestine, but the Beast shifts, their other arm coming up with a screech-creak of metal before cold steel grips her head, squeezing with brutal ease.

Adora hears more than feels her skull fracture. The sight in one eye goes dark. A wrist dislocates as the Beast rips her off their form and hurls her into a tree. Agony ripples up her back before being replaced with terrifying numbness.

But miracle of miracles, she's still holding the sword.

" *FOR THE HONOR OF* ***GRAYSKULL*** !"

The bark of the tree splinters and cracks and the entire trunk groans as she propels herself off of it mid-fall. Her enlarged form hits the ground hands first and she bounds forward on all fours, slamming into the Beast's back in two jumps. Crystal claws spear past the fur, slicing into flesh and bone, neatly bisecting the lower spine.

They collapse and She-Ra follows them down, stabbing indiscriminately. Again and again and—

BANG!

Adora has been shot before. Numerous times. This though…this is different. The concussive force of impact sends her sailing off the Beast, landing heavily a foot or two away. It's not enough to keep her down but even as she scrambles to her feet, she can feel the way the wounds heal oddly.

Laser and plasma Horde weaponry *burns* , but rarely goes more than a layer or three deep. Oh sure, a high frequency shot could pierce the body but those tended to be slower firing precision rifles and the like. The danger, for regular people, is the way the heat from a shot sinks into the body, boiling liquids and heating the body up from the inside out, causing dangerous overheating and often rupturing blood vessels at the point of impact. Couple that with often first degree burns, cracked and broken bones and just sheer shock from the impact and it made for a deadly combination.

Adora, especially as She-Ra, didn't tend to have such a problem. Her body regulated the influx of heat appropriately, often causing steam to burst from her mouth and nose like a hairy dragon. Burns healed in heartbeats, her already strong bones were made even stronger than normal, and blood vessels knitted themselves back together almost as quickly as they ruptured.

RATTATATTATTATTATTAT!

These weapons explode and shatter and bury themselves on the inside. She can feel them, metal bullets, shredding on impact and shredding even more as her body tries to expel them. They tangle and catch on her intestines and she coughs and hacks blood even as the tree she rolls behind is shredded under fire into firewood.

One assailant, wearing a thicker, heavier sort of Horde armor she's never seen before seems to be limited by range and they attempt to flank. She lunges, batting the weapon barrel aside even as it goes off, shredding her ear and part of the flesh off on her left side. Her foot slams down on their as her claws slide neatly in the gaps of their armor, cutting through flesh and bone and with a grunt she levers the entire helmeted head off like Catra flicking the top off a bottle of cream.

RATTATATTATTATTATTAT!

The headless body jerks and shakes as metal slugs slam through it. She-Ra is already gone, launching up and across tree trunks coming down with a roar onto a similarly armored soldier wielding a large, cumbersome looking weapon. It's a monstrous looking thing, black and bulky and clearly heavy, judging by the slowness the bulky lizardman holding it displays as they struggle to lift it about to track her. Glinting metal bullets linked together on an odd looking bandolier connect from the barrel to a pack on the soldier's back and steaming metal shells litter the ground at their feet, streaming out the weapon's side.

All this She-Ra notes seconds before she collides with the Horde soldier, claws first. The impact knocks them off their feet, though

how much it matters, with her claws carving into their heart and lungs, is up in the air. And soon enough so are they; as they fall She-Ra tucks and rolls, tumbling onto her feet and hurling the figure into one of their fellows. She doesn't know which one's bones shatter at the impact but for the moment the one still closest to life is sprawled under their squadmate-turned-projectile.

The fourth soldier makes the mistake of following the sight of their comrades being slammed into each other and by the time their survival instinct snaps back into place it's too late. Crystal claws slice through their armor to bury into their gut and they give a strangled, sobbing scream as she lifts them with one hand and slams the claws of her other into their suspended body half a dozen times, blood splattering onto her upturned face and glimmering curls. There's the sound of movement to her left and she casually throws her Horde-ka-bob onto the wiggling soldier who had just recovered from being a human crash pad.

RATTATATTATTATTATTAT!

A handful of bullets bury themselves into her shoulder and she snarls, transferring the momentum of the impact into turning and lunging on all fours toward her target. A flick of the claw removes their hand from their wrist, a kick to the knee sends them clutching their obliterated kneecap and wailing to the ground, and a quick readjustment to her grip turns their bulky weapon into her new mace.

They're probably dead after the first two strikes, but she lands three more for good measure.

And then there was one.

"Please," the soldier begs and they take off their helmet (the visor shattered, She-Ra notes) with a shaking hand. The other is limp and bleeding at their side, dripping lifeblood into the earth as they gaze beseechingly up at her. "Please, no. I-I surrender. Okay? I surrender."

She-Ra stalks to loom over them. They shake and whimper and quietly sob as they stare at her, prey unable to gaze away from the predator.

(For a moment, she is all too aware of the way her fangs press into her lips and the watering of her mouth.)

A impatient jerk of her head and the soldier scrambles away on all fours, before stumbling to their feet and beginning a limping run towards—

A shadow. A blur. A *scream* .

The Beast looms, a massive form compared to the Horde soldier trapped under their bulk. Their long, curving claws are buried in their comrades' side and as they casually twist and dig, the trooper screams in agony. The other arm, made of gleaming steel, strokes their mane in mocking contemplation.

“You know, you almost proved me wrong,” they chuckle. The claws carve deeper. The trooper wails. “Here I thought you might actually be ruthless enough to do whatcha had to. I have to hear all this whining about how terrible and monstrous the *She-Ra* , the *Wolverine* of the Rebellion is. After all, your handiwork at the—what do they call it?—Fright Zone Massacre? Not bad.”

There's a tearing squelch and the soldier gives a choked moan. The Beast rises languidly to their feet, a dripping dark piece of flesh dangling from their claws. Liver, She-Ra notes in the back of her mind, icy blue eyes watching the organ disappear down the hybrid’s gullet.

“Guess the Rebellion made you soft, eh, Cadet?”

A large furred foot rose only to slam back down and back. There's a crunching noise and the soldier jerks and goes silent.

She-Ra glares. “Who are you?”

The Beast runs a rough tongue over wet and bloody fangs and bares them at her in a facsimile of a grin. “I should be more offended but I heard the witch stirred the pot that was your brainpan. Got some screws loose now, don't you? Ah, but I remember you.” Their metal arm flexed, gears and plates shifting and glinting, blade-like claws clinking as they slide free. “Got this little trinket because of you back at Brightmoon. Well that, and—” they slid their metal claw across the flesh of their palm, grinning as they raised it to face her. She-Ra watched with an icy shiver as the flesh began to swiftly knit back together. “—this.”

Because of her? What did they mean?

"Oh, but you wanted an answer!" They slowly slid into a crouch, claws and fangs bared and eyes alight with a sadistic hunger. "People call me Grizzlor, but to you? You can call me Karma, bitch."

Scorpia breathed deep as she trekked through the woods. Oh sure, the place was a bit dangerous but still! The gentle breeze, the moonlight glinting through the trees, the smell of sap! What a sight. What a smell! Just her, her friends and the beauty of nature.

And no Grizzlor or Entrapta , a part of her mind whispered.

She feels bad thinking such thoughts. Well, about Entrapta. The scientist was a good friend and sport but sometimes…well.

As for Grizzlor…

Scorpia didn't like to be angry. Everybody in the Horde always seemed so angry and her mothers had always encouraged her to "shine even when the clouds darkened". So she tried to be positive and spread that positivity to others! Sure they were at

war, but no reason not to try to find some positives among friends!

Though Grizzlor…

She's not blind to the faults of her home though. Cruelty could be an infection, and she's not blind to the fact that, while things like bloodlines and privilege have no place in the Horde, sometimes the wheels got a little…greasy for her, especially among her fellow Scorpani. (Sometimes. Sometimes they got a little rusty among her fellow Scorpani.) Not that she wouldn't ever give 200%! But uh…she knows that the Force Captain rank was always going to come a little *easier* to her. And that could cause a teensy bit of resentment.

But with Grizzlor…

(*Blood. Guts. The crunch of bone on teeth. The wet slide as flesh was consumed. The begging. The crying. The* screams.)

(Her tail twitches in agitation.)

She wouldn't dare question Lord Hordak's wisdom and Entrapta was much smarter than her.

But Grizzlor…Grizzlor was…

(A brute.)

(A *monster.*)

(*An abomination* .)

(Her pincers click in agitation.)

…a problem.

She—she has to admit, at least to herself, that, Grizzlor's increased prowess or not, she doesn't believe him to be a healthy or beneficial element to the Horde. Or a good representation of the Horde.

(The Rebellion called them the Evil Horde. Baseless slander, she used to say. No one can ever truly be evil, just misunderstood.)

("Help me," the Rebel sobs. Their entrails are being slurped up like spaghetti into Grizzlor's fanged maw. "Dear stars above, *help me* .")

(...right?)

And Entrapta was so fun and eager and has developed such great things! Weapons that overheat less, better armor and stronger bots. The “Adorapaste” that made injuries, major and minor, heal so much faster and more effectively.

(Those metal slinging guns that tore and shredded. Stronger, more incendiary explosives. Grizzlor.)

But…well, it technically wasn't any of Scorpia's business. But the… tanks. The ones she was growing things in. Some had been misshapen and twisted and discarded but two in particular Entrapta seemed really enamored with.

The largest one, the…X24? Was supposed to be Hordak's potential emergency body (and wasn't that a shock, to be told the seemingly indomitable Lord of the Horde was sick? Was *dying* ?) Which, okay! That was smart! Backup plans were important! Even if the idea of Hordak with the Wolverine's abilities (with *Grizzlor's* abilities) made a shiver run through her carapace.

But, uh. X23. The smaller one. The one with the “natural, control growth”. Scorpia didn't really know what to think about that one. Did…did that mean that X23 was a…baby? Entrapta had said she had used magicat DNA, that it was one of the few samples to remain stable. Sure there were magicats around (even if they were rarer these days)—there were even a handful in the Horde. But somehow, Scorpia doubted they'd given up a sample. And there was one (witty, smart, beautiful) magicat they'd been running into a lot over the past year or two…

(Did… did that mean that Adora…and Catra…technically had a—)

Kyle screamed bloody terror, and Scorpia whipped around to see one of those massive Rebellion wolves grab the man-boy by his armor and pull him into the forest depths.

Lonnie swore and Rogelio roared but another wolf leapt from between the trees, snapping at them with massive fangs. Gleaming armor had been carefully fitted onto them and it rippled in the moonlight as the wolf stalked back and forth, eyes glowing with magic.

“Now, now,” they growled. “We're just going to borrow him for a bit.”

The other Horde troopers who had been milling about the camp, setting up temporary structures and outlining sections where the eventual forward camp would be formally built, finally seemed to notice what was going on. One raised his baton and fired. It missed by a mile. Scorpia barely resisted the urge to facepincer.

The wolf grinned. It was disconcerting to say the least. “I'll assume that was a warning shot and not an opening act.”

Lonnie shot her a frustrated look and belatedly, Scorpia realized she was waiting for an order. “For the Horde! Attack!”

The wolf looked positively *delighted* and even as she charged, Scorpia's stomach sank.

“Oh, calm down.” Every time she saw him, Catra couldn't believe Kyle was still alive. Shouldn't he have tripped and broken his neck walking down a hallway by now? She could almost respect his apparent tenacity if not for moments like this, where rather than spitting in their faces like a soldier with any self-respect, he was trembling like a leaf.

Kyle's throat worked, but no sound came out. His eyes darted about, not at them but…past them? Catra frowned, glancing back and trying to track his gaze.

Bow, the ever empathic one, figured it out first. “Adora's not here. She's on a mission.”

“Bow!” Glimmer hissed.

But it worked. Kyle's breathing began to steady, but Catra felt her claws flex in irritation at the implications. “She's not some *monster* .”

Kyle gazed at her with a surprising steadiness. “Isn't she?”

Swift Wind, still hyped up by his successful abduction and stalking back and forth around them snarled in fury. "*How dare you*." He shoved his way forward, nearly knocking Catra and Bow off their feet. "Adora was a *victim*. *The Horde* made a weapon. And the *witch* made a monster."

Kyle quailed under the massive wolf's gaze.

"Swifty," Bow pleaded. "That's enough." He turned back to Kyle. "Answer some questions and we'll let you go. On my honor."

Kyle's eyes flickered to the other three.

"And theirs." Bow turned to look pointedly.

Swift Wind snarled then huffed. "I swear on my Pack."

"On the Moonstone."

Three pairs of eyes turned to look at Catra. "Yeah, sure, whatever."

"Catra."

“Fine, I swear on Glitter's life.”

“ *Catra* .”

“Fine. Adora's.”

“...close enough.”

Bow turned expectedly towards the trembling Kyle. The blonde swallowed harshly. “Wh-what do you want to know?”

“What is Project X?”

Grizzlor felt like a god.

The Cadet was putting up a fight, and were he anyone else, he might have been in trouble, but she was still just that: a Cadet. Oh sure, she might have been the witch's favorite and she might have modified her own style of combat in the last year or so, but Grizzlor had been a battle-hardened veteran back when she was shitting her diapers. Her form was good, but she used her claws

like they were new, like they didn't belong to her. She took too many hits, so used to her little healing gimmick.

But science had leveled the playing field and gimmicks didn't last in war.

He laughed as her claws cut into him. It was like he was in his prime again, shrugging off blows and seemingly mortal wounds with little more than a chuckle. His claws parted unblemished skin like a hot knife through butter. The wounds healed nearly as quickly they appeared but Grizzlor didn't let that deter him, raining blows upon the magical woman with a savage glee. It was clear that she wasn't used to fighting anyone seriously for more than a handful of moments at a time, as she rocked back time after time from the force of his blows.

Pitiful. This is why the Rebellion kept losing ground, why Horde grunts kept fleeing the battlefield in disgrace. Why the Wolverine scared people shitless.

Nobody fought for *real* aymore, that type of fight not with guns or tanks but with blade and claw, up close, brutal and to the death. The type of fight where blood pooled at your feet, sweat stung your eyes and every move could be your last. The type of fight where legends rose and fell.

Grizzlor decided to consider this fight the golden girl's last lesson. A reward for his entertainment.

He caught her by the cape and hurled her through the branches. She was already adjusting her descent as she fell but it did not matter. He tackled her around the waist as she fell and slammed her through a couple of trees, using her as a battering ram until the forest opened out into a mountain path. He shoves her away as he slides to a stop, throwing her right over the side into the open air towards the village below.

He paused and breathed deep, relishing the burn of his muscles and pounding of his heart and the—

He frowns.

The wounds the cadet had inflicted on him were healing but far too slow. The treatment the egghead had given him wasn't perfect, not yet. She kept delaying things, kept up a drivel of excuses about “absorption rate” and “datasets” and “cell life”. He wasn't listening to be honest—her ceaseless chatter gave him a headache and he's had enough of the Horde having too much talk and not enough action.

Luckily, he had a solution. A plunge into his pocket yielded a slim needle, one of his last. The “Adorapaste” was produced in varying concentrations but he'd snagged some of the most potent and he slammed the needlepoint into his neck, hissing as his body throbbed and burned, his accelerated healing pushed into overdrive, wounds almost steaming in the cool mountain air as they slid shut.

His stomach gurgled and his mouth watered as the hunger, ever present, grew sharper. She-Ra's blood was still wet on his claws. He licked and grinned at the sweetness.

"Mmmm…appetizer."

A click of his claw activated his comm badge. "Team Alpha, Team Gamma is KIA. Tango is in Quadrant 1, move in. Team Beta, move into Quadrant 2."

Grizzlor doesn't wait to hear the affirmation before he leaps into the void to continue the hunt.

She-Ra clipped her pilfered radio to her belt, cursing the magical lack of pockets. A real pity—apparently her smokes were in her other clothes. She clicked her tongue in annoyance and a quick flex of her powerful thighs propelled her onto a nearby roof and she gazed out over the capital of Dryl.

She didn't remember much regarding her last visit, but given the reports she'd read, it hadn't looked much different then as it did now—practically deserted. At least of civilians—she could see some Horde troops here and there and the shadows of others at impromptu checkpoints. She could smell more on the wind and the air rumbled as tanks hovered in and around the square.

Still, it wasn't nearly as busy as it should be. Perhaps because Dryl was technically an “ally” now? Because the Horde simply wouldn't bother sending a massive battalion to the kingdom so long as too much trouble wasn't given and the mines were operating as scheduled?

Or, she considered, eyes meeting the darkly armored soldier crouched on a roof perpendicular to her own, it was because they were waiting for her. Because the smart ones had gotten out of the way and the trap had been sprung.

Tile shattered beneath her feet as she lunged through the air, cape flapping in the wind. The soldier was frozen for a beat too long as they gaped at her behind their helmet. By the time they tried to aim their gun, a longer, slimmer variant, she crashed into them. Her claws stabbed into their shoulders and she used her leverage to heft herself up and over them, landing bodily on her feet and hurling them up into the nearby chimney stack.

The brick work seems to explode under the impact, stone shattering and crumbling and sliding and clattering down the shaft and to the cobblestone below. The soldier's body telescopes and slumps onto the tile, limbs askew and twitching.

She-Ra picks up the rifle, her hands testing the sights, the trigger and magazine with a familiarity that feels foreign and a confusion that feels familiar.

(Top of the class, Catra had told her. She had been top of her class, fast-tracked towards an officer position. She had excelled at

everything she put her mind to. How long would that have lasted on the field, she wonders. Would Adora the Force Captain have been The Wolverine of the Horde? Was she always destined to be a killer?)

(Sometimes, in the deepest parts of her heart Adora wishes she knew more about Adora of the Horde beyond Catra's stories, because as much as much of the Rebellion liked to pretend, Force Captain Adora has been the bulwark upon which Adora the Rebel was built, and it was moments like this where she felt the girl's corpse hanging about her shoulders and weighing her down.)

There is barking in the radio as the rest of Team Alpha starts to realize that almost half their number isn't responding. She-Ra presses her eye to the sights. The weapon is a tad too small in her hands and her hand placement is off, but it still works well enough for her to send a bullet through a darkly clad trooper's helmet as they turn the corner.

The kick of the recoil surprises her but not too much to shift targets towards the furthermost right and fire. *Flanking technique B-3* , Force Captain Adora whispers. The bullet tears through their jaw in a marvelous spray of steel, bone and crimson. They collapse, clawing at their ruined face.

Below her feet she can faintly hear muffled cries of fear and confusion and in the courtyard below she can see Horde soldiers rushing to and fro and a single black-armoured being crouched behind a statue, trying to pinpoint her location. She could stay in her position but the average Horde soldier wasn't exactly a sharp shooter and more importantly, didn't care about collateral.

She slid off the roof and hit the ground running, scooping up a broken brick in each hand as she hurtled across the courtyard. There were yells as a couple of soldiers caught sight of her but at least two were silenced as her bricks became lethal projectiles under the strength of a demigod.

The last black trooper figured things out too late and poked their head around the statue, opening fire. Presumably (not unreasonably) they expected She-Ra to skate around in an attempt to get at them.

It is highly unlikely, in any scenario, that they would have predicted her simply drop-kicking the statue.

The base simply shatters under her strength and the marble man, probably Dryl's founder or first king, keels over. The unfortunate soldier, knocked onto their ass from the force of their barricade exploding, barely has time to scream before a thousand pounds of stone crumble onto them with a nasty squelch.

She-Ra clambers onto the makeshift grave to survey the landscape. Soldiers cautiously inched towards her, glancing at each other in barely concealed panic. Some half-heartedly raised their weapons.

“Walk away.” Her voice boomed across the square. “Walk away or die here.”

“Die by my hand or hers.”

She-Ra turns, glaring as Grizzlor stalks the square. Her eyes narrow as she takes in his form. His healing was impressive, almost on par with her own it seemed. Almost. They were faint, incredibly so, but she could see scars between the fur and some were a tad too pink. And whatever treatment he'd been given clearly wasn't enough if his arm hadn't grown back.

That didn't make him any less dangerous.

“Anyone who runs,” Grizzlor bellows, “I will personally—”

She-Ra doesn't let him finish. She lunges, grappling the beastman with a snarl. She's strong, fierce.

But he's stronger and fiercer still.

“Oh, Cadet,” he tuts, shattering her knee with a hammer strike and sending her sprawling. “When ya going to learn? It's kill or be killed out here.” Claws tangled themselves into her golden tresses, the tips cutting into her scalp. Grizzlor hefted her up before slamming her head into the cobblestone, the stone cracking beneath the force.

“No hesitation!”

Crunch.

“No mercy!”

Crunch.

“**No weakness!**”

CRUNCH!

She-Ra could feel the darkness creeping into her vision, the stabbing agony of stone shards shredding through her skull, juxtaposed with the floaty, stretchy feeling as the magic of the sword begàn to flicker and die, Adora's grasp of the goddess fading with her consciousness.

The claws in her hair pulled her up and back, holding her on her knees. The ground seemed to shake beneath her. She felt the wet heat of the Force Captain's breath on her ear a split moment before his slimy tongue dragged itself up the side of her face, licking the flowing blood from her features with a pleased hum.

“And of course, something Weaver never taught your coddled ass: *no second chances* .”

He released her with a laugh. His presence moved away, yet the tumbling and shaking only seemed to grow stronger, closer, worse. Blinking blood from her eyes, her hazy vision skid gracelessly across her surroundings, passing over the large craft now directly in front of her twice before she managed to focus on it.

Ah. That was a tank.

The three hazy barrels wavered in front of as they took aim at her prone figure. She tried to push herself to her knees only to fail, her legs no longer responding. She absently wonders if it's the slate shards in her skull or the apparently broken knee causing the issue.

The tank barrel glow was her only warning and all she could do was raise her claws in a futile attempt to guard herself as the verdant tank shell smashed into her body and everything went dark.

Scorpia groaned, gritting her teeth at the ripple of pain in her ribs and raising her eyes to meet that of the smug wolf's lazily pacing in front of them. About the clearing her soldiers were groaning

and whimpering, spawled about or wisely staying down. At least she hoped the quiet ones were just trying to avoid attention.

Alive or dead, they were all out of commission, taken out by a single combatant and the bitter taste of failure mixed poorly with the iron in her mouth. Shame and anger swirled in her heart.

Another setback. Another notch in the belt of insults and cruelty and disrespect her fellow captains draped about her shoulders. It meant more mocking, more disdain, more—

No, no. Breathe, Scorpia. No doubts, no insecurities. Face the world with a smile.

She stumbled to her feet, widening her stance as she stared down the wolf. It was one of She-Ra's wolves, a massive creature whose head easily reached her chest. And this was one of the smaller ones. Not that had stopped it from being able to pick up and throw skiffs, trees and people about like toys.

But Scorpia was plenty strong herself and she's had a fsir few bouts with the Rebellion at this point. She's been watching them, learning their moves and she's confident rhat now that the element of surprise has been lost this wolf will…will…

“Hey,” she yells at the creature's retreating back. “We're not done!”

The wolf glanced back, but didn't stop, a dismissive sort of contempt on its furry face.

Scorpia's pincers clenched. “I'll remember this!”

The wolf paused and for a moment Scorpia thought they would come back only for something unpleasant to churn in her gut as it barked out a laugh.

“Glad I'm worth remembering!” They jeered, turning away again with a dismissive flick of their tail but pitching their voice to be heard loud and clear even as they slipped between the trees. “Wish I could say the same!”

Scorpia stood there, surrounded by the ruins of her camp, still staring into the trees.

Wish I could say the same.

She was a Force Captain, the strongest one in the ranks.

Wish I could say the same.

She was the scion of royalty, the last of a centuries old bloodline, part of a legacy of survival and adaption, war and innovation.

Wish I could say the same.

She was…she was…

“Scorpia!”

“What?!?”

Lonnie reared back, surprise and a hint of fear flickering over her features. Scorpia hadn't been aware of the slowly building noise of the camp soldiers taking stock of damage and injuries until all the sound stopped with a surprised hush. She's no stranger to people looking at her but in that moment she's all too aware of the gazes of her soldiers on her back and the way she's nursing her ribs. She straightens, ignoring the pain to stare down at Lonnie. “Sit-rep corporal.”

Lonnie blinked uncertainly. “It's…not great Scorpia—”

“Force Captain, *corporal* .”

"...right. Err, sorry Force Captain, Ma'am. Situation is…yellow, I think? Hostiles appear to have left the area but the we're still taking stock of our losses—"

"Get it done. Salvage what we can, tell everyone to prepare the injured for march, and set up a watch. We're breaking camp at dawn."

"O-okay. Ma'am, what about Kyle?"

Earlier today, Scorpia would have mustered an entire small force to go after the boy. No one left behind, after all.

Her chest seems cold and her voice far away when she says, "Either he makes it back or he doesn't. We don't have resources to spare for a weak link."

Lonnie opens her mouth, but Scorpia's stare makes her snap her jaw shut, hesitantly salute and slowly trudge away with a final backwards glance. Scorpia glanced back at the trees, her gaze far away.

Wish I could say the same.

She stalks toward the camp proper, not even noticing the way the troops scurry out of her way, their eyes trained on the dangerous upturned curl of her stinger.

Glimmer rarely felt fear.

From the moment she first saw a set of refugees, begging tearfully at her mother's throne for gold and food to try to rebuild their lives Glimmer knew she would destroy the Horde or die trying. They were the reason her mother wandered the halls at night like a ghost, the reason there was a near permanent tent city on the edges of the palace grounds. They caused misery and pain wherever they went and so Glimmer would not allow herself to feel fear when facing them. *She* would show them fear.

But sometimes fear had a way of creeping up on a girl—like now.

“Entrapta used Adora's body to make a monster?”

“ *Can every Horde soldier do that?*"

"Uh, no. It's just me. I heal fast.”

Catra bristled beside her. “And a healing solution.”

“That's not better!” In fact, that was objectively worse.

Part of what made the Horde so dangerous was the fact that they tended to throw bodies, organic or otherwise, at the problem until they succeeded in their goals. On that same note, that's what made them vulnerable: soldiers on the caliber of Catra and Adora were rare and their defection, while arguably small in impact, was still devastating in the long-term. Beyond being excellent fighters, both had been groomed for officer positions; even Catra, supposedly set up to play second fiddle to her blonde counterpart, was stIll designed to be her second in terms of command. This meant, as harsh and abusive as it was, extensive time and effort had been put into their training and education, all of which had been lost with their betrayal. While the Horde had numbers, they still relied on figureheads in the form of their Force Captains and Majors to ensure those numbers were used and directed effectively. Poor management coupled with their "survival of the fittest" mentality meant even their numbers could be severely dented due to maneuvers, traps, bad morale and even worse health care.

Having a solution that could rival magic in healing prowess was devastating. Their commander's effect couldn't be understated, but if they had a better chance of fielding their soldiers almost immediately after their injuries…

She gripped the Horde soldier, Kyle, by his collar, practically lifting him. "Where is this stuff made?"

"Th-the Fright Zone!"

The heart of enemy territory. Glimmer grit her teeth. Of course it couldn't be easy.

“I mean, technically that's good!” Bow tried. “Less casualties. And even getting put back together doesn't make it less annoying to get beat up in the first place. Plus, no knockoff can beat the real deal. Adora can beat anything they throw at her!”

Maybe. But they weren't all like Adora. Glimmer shoved Kyle away. “Get out of here.” The Horde soldier started to scramble away but paused at Catra's call.

“Kyle.” The magicat looked uncomfortable but soldiered through. “If you or Lonnie and Rogelio ever get tired or sick of the Horde… Rebellion can take you in or set you up somewhere else. I'll vouch for you. Even if you three are a pain in my ass.”

Glimmer grit her teeth but said nothing. Redemption and reconciliation were major parts of the Rebellion, even if it did open them up to more Horde swanning in and getting pardons as if nothing they'd done mattered. As if their crimes of serving an evil dictator meant nothing.

Kyle looked stunned, but gave an awkward, jerky nod before he scurried away.

Glimmer barely spared him another glance as she focused on the issue at hand. She rolled the small tube of solution between her fingers. The less viscous it was the better Kyle claimed. The thicker paste versions had other medical materials mixed in make up for their low concentration of Adorapaste. She pulled her

dagger from her boot and sliced her palm with a hiss, watching the dark crimson lifeblood spill over her fingers.

“Glimmer!” Bow started forward only to be held back by Catra.

Glimmer spurt a pea-sized bit of gel onto her wound, hissing as she rubbed the solution into her flesh and hissing some more as it warmed up considerably, throbbing as the gel instantly went to work. Within moments the pain began to fade and moments later, as she rinsed her hand with a splash of water from her canteen, the only sign of her injury was a thin, angry pink line across her palm. Bow broke free and gripped her hand, both marveling over the quick healing and fussing over the remaining scar.

“Glimmer! That was way too reckless! What if—!”

“We need to make our own Adorapaste.” The Princess's mind was awhirl with possibilities. “What Entrapta does with tech we can do better with magic. We have the brightest minds in Etheria at Mystacor and she's only dealing with scraps. We have the genuine article to sample from—”

“No.” Catra stepped into Glimmer's space, eyes alight with anger. “No one is using Adora as a test subject.”

“She wouldn't be a test subject but if we can make anyone else the slightest bit tougher through her blood and stuff—”

“You mean like the Horde?” Catra sneered, a reversal of their earlier interaction and Glimmer felt her frustration rise.

“No, not like the *Horde* , but if the Horde is already using her to get a edge—”

“—so we just do the same, that's it—”

“—the Rebellion can't rely on just her—”

“—poke and prod at her like she's not a *person* —”

“—she would gladly volunteer and you know that—”

“—Princesses are all the same—”

Swift Wind's snarl broke through their bickering, but the wolf wasn't focused on them. His glowing gaze was far away, gazing into the east, no, northeast. Towards Dryl. Magic wafted from his fur like steam and his teeth were bared in a snarl. “Adora's in trouble.”

“What do—”

The wolf didn't wait, the glow of his fur growing more intense as he crouched in preparation. Catra, quicker on the uptake, cursed as she lunged forward, bodily straddling the enormous lupine seconds before he disappeared in a streak of rainbow, darting through the trees faster than the eye could track, Catra's echoing yells of panic the only sign that either had been there at all.

Glimmer could only stare at where they'd disappeared for a moment before her gaze was drawn back to the tube and everything it represented.

“Glimmer.” Bow's warm hand grasped her shoulder, his gaze unusually grave. “We've got to trust that we can do this if we want to win this war. We've got to trust each other. And Adora has had enough violations.”

She flinched at the reminder. The crackle of crimson lightning and the agonized howls of pain melting onto ferality still occasionally haunted her dreams. “...right,” she breathed. “You're right. I just…”

He smiled at her with that gentle understanding and she wondered how anyone could be so perfect. “I know.”

Still, as Faolin and Akera thundered through the trees with their eyes aglow and their fur ruffled with anxiety and Bow turned to fill them in, Glimmer kept touching the tube in her pocket. And wondering.

“She's awake!”

No, she's not, Adora wanted to grumble, trying in vain to ignore the growing pain that threatened to fully pull her out of her blissful state of unconsciousness. Five more minutes—

The pain went from present to agonizing and she couldn't help but cry out as something in her gut was pulled, sending a wave of fire through her entire body.

Lifting her eyelids was a herculean effort and she only barely succeeded with one. The other refused to move and she resigned herself to limited vision as she slowly blinked, clearing her blurred sight to look at the source of her latest discomfort.

Ah. There it was.

…

That was a pickaxe. There was a pickaxe in her stomach.

Someone slapped her on her blind side with a heavy, powerful hand and she hissed as it jostled her worn and battered body. Her neck cracked as she raised it glare at her assaulter. She's not surprised but certainly is sick of coming face to face with Grizzlor's ugly mug.

“The princess is awake from her royal slumber.” He flicked the edge of the bloody pickaxe, the vibration sending a lurch of pain through her intestines. “We hope the accommodations are to your liking.”

The accommodations in question appeared to be a dimly lit room of sorts. They were underground—not simply a basement but an underground room. She could feel the rasp and bite of jagged rock at her back and smell the metal, crystal and oil in the stone. A mine then. So they hadn't left Dryl yet. Why?

The answer came quickly. They hadn't simply thrown her in a forge to melt so they wanted her alive which meant they had to transport her. The chains that draped over her arms and across her neck and chest weren't true shackles—most were rusted and Grizzlor's soldiers had gone for quality over quantity. The only true restraint device were the glowing shackles that wrapped around her ankles, far too small and tight and making her feet numb.

So they were prepared enough to set a trap of sorts to capture her, but weren't prepared enough to take her in. Arrogance or oversight?

“Zero out of ten,” she snarked back, trying to emulate Catra's special brand of disrespect and irreverence. “Would not come back. Honestly it's not the atmosphere, it's the company.”

Grizzlor bared his teeth in a mockery of a smile, gripping the exposed pickaxe head and shoving the whole thing further into her large intestine. “The Cadets got jokes I see. Well here's one: what's gold, red and all worn out?”

“Your career.”

He snapped the waistband of her pants. “You in the cells. The geek princess only wants your body for science. There's a fair few in the FZ that wouldn't mind getting a piece for some payback.”

“You think that scares me?”

“Nah. I think it'll be fun. Might even have a taste myself. Although…I'll admit that you're not my type. I prefer mine a bit more flexible and feisty. That cat of yours fits the bill. Maybe if you're nice, she can join you.”

Adora only realizes she's trying to lunge forward when the chains about her neck squeeze the air from her lungs and spots appear in her vision from the lack of oxygen. She falls back panting, barely cognizant of the way her bloody, dislocated wrist starts trying to knit itself back together.

Grizzlor laughed until he wheezed, his trio of troops joining in, save one, who looked a bit uncomfortable. “Hoo, it's like watching a starving dog chase a stripped bone.” He turned and began to walk away into the tunnel system proper, and Adora's eye was drawn to her sword, strapped to his back. “Hang tight, Cadet. It won't be long now. Feel free to choke yourself out.”

The troops left behind arranged themselves around her: two at the door and an unlucky fellow on her right side, at the end of the room. All were equipped with those heavy, black rifles. All were tense, and smelled of fear and anger.

Holding pattern G-3 , Force Captain Adora whispers. *Textbook.*

Limited numbers. The Horde would be stretched thin above ground as is. The tunnels were too narrow for bots. Grizzlor was banking on his elite to keep her contained until transport. Assuming the weaponry was prototype and limited and the numbers of Gamma and Alpha had been the same, there would be…yes. Two more scents, unknown, down the corridor. More on the wind, even fainter. A small force blocking the entrance. But only two to keep her within the system proper?

Focus , Rebel Captain Adora growled. *Examine your surroundings. Examine your tools.*

She was chained. Grizzlor had her sword. Her pockets had been emptied, their contents laid out on a little shelf in the room: her

communicator, the stolen radio, a few carefully wrapped cigars, and her lighter.

She let herself fall back with a rattle of chains, partially to take the weight of her feet and partially to glance up as she cracked and craned her neck, feigning exhaustion to gaze at the ceiling and walls through hooded eyes.

There was only one light in the room but, she noted with some surprise, it wasn't crystal or electric but flame, one of the old fashioned ones in a glass casing webbed with iron.

While most used crystal powered magitech these days, fire as light and heat wasn't exactly rare, but tended to depend on where you lived. Those in and around the regions Brightmoon and Plumeria tended to simply use wood and oil imported from Salineas, who used fish oils for all manner of things and occasionally the black oils from beneath the seabed, though that tended to be an arduous and messy affair. The Fright Zone used a mix of coal from their mines and geothermal power from deep within the desert ravines, below the civilian and Scorpani villages. And Dryl used crystal of course and occasionally coal and even rarer…

Her gaze drifted from the light above to the thin but strong piping connected to it and anchored onto and in and out of the rock above, jutting out to connect to a sturdy looking pipe wheel before going back into the rock.

…gas.

It wasn't a complete unknown but the care needed to extract, store and contain the substance meant it was usually either burned away or limited to careful usage in mining regions. The oldness of the hewed walls around her coupled with the steadiness of the flame suggested that whatever type of mining operation had been going had either been halted or stalled by the discovery of a large gas deposit and efforts had been redirected into dispersal and containment.

The plan snapped together in her head. And Adora grinned with savage fury, already tasting iron on her tongue.

They threaten your Pack. They threatened Catra, The Wolverine snarls. *Kill. Them. All.*

“What are you smiling for, traitor?” One of the troopers at the door barked.

Young. Impertinent. Quick to anger.

Perfect.

“Thinking about the odds.”

“You're not going to escape. Grizzlor will put your ass in the dirt.”

“Not about that. I'm wondering if you'll piss yourself before or after my Pack tears you to shreds.”

“You—” they shrugged past their partner's attempts to hold them back, taking an aggressive step forward. “I can't wait to see you screaming on the Princess's table. I hope I get a turn to cut out your heart.”

“Parn—” the one at the back of the room started cautiously.

“No! This bitch killed all of Alpha and Gamma. Heaver, Gren, Ion. They're all dead because of her! And we don't even get that satisfaction, do we? Because this freak won't die.”

“Is all you do is bitch?” Adora grumbles, gazing lazily at the furious soldier. “We both know the score. You can't kill me and we both know you won't even try without your furry daddy keeping watch.” She tilted her head at the shelf before she let it droop seemingly in exhaustion. “You're an errand boy. Now grab me a light and I might not disembowel you when I get out of here.”

Even the other door guard bristled at that. The first trooper made a furious choking noise.

“Oh. Ohhohoho.” They strode over and snatched the lighter from the shelf. It was a fancy Brightmoon type, gold-plated, slim and

shaped like an elongated lipstick tube. “You want a light traitor? I'll give you a light.” With a click of its side, the lighter ignited, the small flame a steady blue. “Open wide.”

“Parn—!”

“Shut up!” Thickly padded gloves harshly gripped her hair. “The boss won't care if we rough—”

Adora lurched forward and up, slamming the back of her head into the trooper's chin. He stumbled, but still kept his grip on her hair. Her fangs flashed in the dim lighting, burying themselves into his other hand and mauling it with a quick shake. He screamed as he released her hair to grab at his ruined limb and with a heave, she rocked back and lifted herself up with the chains, planting her bound feet into his chest and sending him bodily across the room to slam into the opposite wall. The light above flickered and died.

The other guards were yelling into their radios, calling for medics and back-up and one raised their weapon but froze at her glare.

“You fucked up!” They yelled, trying to conceal their fear with bravado. “You had one chance and you blew it!”

Pounding footsteps echoed in the tunnel. Adora turned her head to gaze at the nervous guard inching closer and inclined her head at the cracked wall across from her, flashing her bloody teeth and the object between them.

To their credit, they sniffed the air and put two and two together, hurrying forward and hopping over their comrade’s insensate body. “Run!”

“What—?”

“It's going to blow!!”

The other guard sniffed the air and took off a second later.

There was chaos as the two guards hurried out and slammed into their backup and overlapping yelling as professionalism broke down but Adora was too busy maneuvering the lighter in her teeth and counting down the seconds to focus.

By the time the burning scent of gas sat heavy in the air and had made her eyes water and coated the back of her tongue, several soldiers had gotten their wits about them and stormed into the room, though only two had those heavy black guns. The rest of Beta squad it seemed.

Adora only grumbled as their headlights seared into her eyes. “Dumbasses.”

This is going to sting.

With a press of her jaw, the lighter clicked.

They coughed raggedly as they regained consciousness. Their filter was shot, torn off in the explosion and they gagged and hacked at the hot blood, dust and ash that clogged itself into the back of their throat and nose. Their training had them running a diagnostic in their mind even as they tried in vain to clear the burning dust and microscopic stone from their eyes.

Nothing felt broken at least. Nico had been convinced to go back and confront the Wolverine, even knowing the danger. Or perhaps trying to save Parn. They had known from the moment they'd heard the crunch of bone and by the way he'd ragdolled into dust that there was no saving him.

Honestly, from the moment the Wolverine had arrived, there was no saving any of them. They'd been part of the clean-up after the Massacre. They'd fought at the Battle of Brightmoon. No amount of “advanced prototype” armor or weapons would be enough to stop someone like her. Nothing with that kind of tenacity and ferocity and sheer unmitigated fury could be stopped by the mere mortals or magic.

The Horde propaganda liked to act asnif she was just abother Princess, barely hokding bsck their innumerable tides throufh deceit and desperation. They knew the true, had known it from

the moment they'd heard that roar echonover the tree in the light of the moon:

They were all dead. They just didn't know it yet.

Crunch.

They froze, heart pounding so fast and hard it was almost painful. Behind them, from the direction of the room—the sound of feet slapping over blackened gravel.

Crunch.

They bit their lip so hard they tasted copper. If they didn't make a noise or move or anything, maybe they could—

Shh-crunch!

Terrified eyes slid to the side. A pickaxe, bloody, ashy and horrifically familiar was buried into the earth, uncomfortably close to their neck. Slowly, mute with terror, they craned their neck up and back, staring at the looming figure hovering over them.

SCHNIK!

They closed their eyes as a strong foot landed on her chest and hot breath, meaty, metallic and moist, grazed their ear as the Wolverine spoke, those infamous claws pricking at their neck, steady despite the fury in her voice.

" *Strip* . And then you're going to do exactly what I say."

Grizzlor snarled as his comm only spat static. So much for an "elite" force. All of them had been worthless. A reflection of the state of Horde if he's ever seen one: even their best were utter crap.

He has a decision. As much as he would love to hunt down the Cadet for a proper brawl, the fact of the matter was he was starting to feel some of those aches from the wounds she'd afflicted. And as furious as that made him there was also the fact that he had an actual mission here.

Capturing the—ugh—Wolverine was secondary to the true prize: the sword. And now that he had it in his possession, Hordak would want him to hightail it back to the Fright Zone so his princess not-girlfriend could study it. And despite his aggravation, Grizzlor was still loyal to the Horde.

~~(But Hordak was not the Horde, was he? Not anymore. It had grown past him. Beyond him.~~

~~Maybe it was time they did the same.)~~

"GRIZZLOR!"

Then again—good things came to those who waited.

He grinned, flexing his claws as the Cadet came charging down the tunnel. She was dressed in one of his soldier's body suits and she looked worse for the wear, missing most of her hair and her eyebrows, but her eyes were still alight with that fire that made Grizzlor's heart pound.

She charged forward on all fours and Grizzlor roared in excitement as he did the same. A fraction of a second before they impacted, the Cadet abruptly twisted into a leg forward slide that took her under and past his larger frame. The feeling of exposed air followed by burning pain and his sudden inability to walk told him everything and he snarled as he slid to a stop and maneuvered himself to pursue the fleeing Rebel on three legs, silently thankful she'd only had time to hamstring him. He wasn't sure he could lose another limb.

They darted through the tunnels, a game of cat and mouse. He managed to surprise her at a junction and he cackled as his claw sliced up her spine but she rolled away and hurled a stone at him

with lightning speed, cracking his eye socket. He pursued despite his injury only to get blindsided at another junction and sent sprawling as she sliced through his Achilles heel. All of this was made ever more frustrating and exciting by the fact that half the tunnel system was dark, many of the gas powered lights no longer being fed.

“Stop running!” He roared into the tunnels as he chased the Cadet's scent. “Face me!”

He burst into a central tunnel, its floor lined with cold iron. Before he could react something landed on his shoulders, and the weight of the sword disappeared from his back. He roared and lashed out with incredible reflexes, smacking the Cadet down the corridor, the sword skittering along the ground.

“Heh. Neat little trick,” he chuckled, stalking towards the fallen Wolverine and kicking the sword up into his hand as went. “But here's some advice: gimmicks don't last long. Tricks only work once. And experience will always level the playing field.”

And to his astonishment the girl started to chuckle.

“I know,” she looked up at him with blood-stained teeth and an insufferably smug gleam in her eye. “That's why I learned a new one. It's called ‘self-preservation’. You might call it ‘treason’, though. Either way,” she exaggerated tilted her head to look past him. “It looks like it worked.”

Dryl's mine tram systems were some of the best in the world. Fast, quiet and smooth, they practically glided along their tracks, and were always independently powered by crystal matrices, as so not to strand the workers deep below should there be an accident or if the main generators went out. They were also quite heavy, being designed to cart not only people, but significantly heavier robots and equipment.

Force Captain and Rebel Captain Adora knew all this, just as they'd known to memorize the basic outline of every main tunnel system along the Dryl mountain range before they'd set out, just as they'd known where to send the sole (and unfortunately nude) surviving soldier. Because all parts of Adora knew their luck and they knew that inevitability, something like this would happen: them lunging and stabbing Grizzlor in the knees and spine as he turned to face the oncoming tram carts with a snarl, keeping him pinned and immobile as best they could as the cart rammed into the struggling duo at full speed.

Having a massive body as a makeshift cushion helped but the impact still made her teeth rattle hard enough to crack one and her neck throbbed at the whiplash. Grizzlor was dragged half under the lead car, roaring in fury as he clutched at the edge, nearly tipping the whole thing over. Adora rolled up and over him, landing heavily in the cart and scrambling to her feet to stab at his hand, pinning it to the cart. He bellowed in fury and tried to take her head off with the sword, but she ducked and stabbed up, impaling his wrist and forcing him to drop the weapon. She had to wrench her claws out to grab it and barely managed to take hold of it before it was lost as the tunnels sped on through.

“I'LL WEAR YOUR SKIN AS A SCARF!” The Force Captain raged, claws lashing out and tearing a meaty chunk from her shoulder.

She screamed in rage and pain and lunged forward, cracking her crown against the hybrid’s nose. The man gave a gurgling yell as he involuntarily reached for his crushed organ. Adora gladly released his pinned hand and watched as the hybrid disappeared under the cart with a guttural roar.

She collapsed back into the cart, hissing as her shoulder began to knit itself back together. A quarter inch to the left and those claws would have buried themselves in her throat. For the first time in a long time she feels a bone-deep weariness and it frightens her. She can't keep this up, she's not enough, not against the likes of Grizzlor. For all his boasting he's not wrong—he's been fighting and slaughtering since before she was born. Adora, Wolverine—none of them can face this better beast as they are.

Cautiously, she reaches for the magic within her and the sword, but feels only embers. *Come on* , she pleads with the hero deep within her. *I need you* .

The demigoddess is silent.

She's so busy concentrating she almost doesn't hear the scrape of claws over metal until it's too late. She barely has time to try to guard with the sword when over three hundred pounds pounces upon her pinning her down and shoving the crystal blade's edge almost half a inch into her sternum. She chokes then roars in agony as those deadly metal claws bury themselves into her side, absolutely shredding part of her intestines.

Any other person would have gone into shock immediately, assuming their rib cage hadn't simply collapsed from the get-go. As it is, her unique biology is the only thing preventing her from simply being crushed and the only thing stopping Grizzlor from ripping out her throat is her arm and the sword pushing against his throat and under his ribs. The only thing stopping him from disemboweling her completely is his sadism.

He grins maniacally as he squeezes and crushes three ribs into powder from the inside out, half his face shredded nearly to the bone from being dragged about under the tram. Both their arms are slippery and gritty with blood and drool and dust and she can't tell where her blood flow stops and his begins. Her claws tear out and punctures a lung and he chokes out a mouthful of blood into her eyes.

These are the kinds of battles never sung about in the Rebellion or the Horde. The savage, brutal, filthy ones where survival comes down to who can hold out longer while locked together in a gory embrace.

(Deep within, Adora, She-Ra, Wolverine, *they* love it.)

(Deeper still, they hate themselves for doing so.)

“Not yet!” Grizzlor gurgles. His eyes are beyond bloodshot, a crimson sclera with a piercing black iris in the center. Never before has he looked so feral. “Not yet! No more tricks! No more running! No more She-Ra and light shows! Show me who you are, Cadet! Show me Adora the Soldier! The Rebel! *THE WOLVERINE* !”

"...should…have… "

Despite himself, Grizzlor leaned closer, curious to hear the girl's last words.

"...pulled…brakes…"

Brakes? Grizzlor blinked and looked up just in time for the cart to smash into a wooden barricade.

It's not enough to stop the speeding carts, made even faster by the way the two's tussling have utterly wrecked the car's controls, but it's enough to nearly send Grizzlor flying right back out of it again. He catches himself, barely, but it has dislodged him from his position and given Adora an opportunity that even her spilling entrails won't distract her from. She stabs.

On the Force Captain's part, for all the pain and wounds he's endured on this day, none of it can compare to the feeling of three foot-long bone claws stabbing their way up into his most sensitive undercarriage.

His scream is loud enough to shake the mountain.

"By the stars above SHUT THE *FUCK UP* !"

Her knees crack with the effort but she levers the wailing monster of a man up and over her. To his credit, he manages to reach an arm back to grab at the hood, metal claws tearing rents into the iron, but Adora follows him, her sword coming over and up to press into his throat, ignoring the way the blade slices into her fingers and palm in favor of using it as an oversized garrote.

They smash into another barricade and he gurgles as his broken body is used as a ram, stunning him. And then again, another barricade. Then another. And another, each one cracking and smashing bone and flesh upon impact.

And with a final bone shattering smash they're surrounded by the blinding setting moons as they careen out of the mines and down the mountainside, tumbling out into the open air.

A flash of moonlight through blurred eyes. Liquid in her nose, mouth, inside and out. She convulses, throat working desperately until the inside wins and she spews her contents, blood and bile and water, her body flopping from the force and half-baked instinct. She hurls and chokes and everything goes blissfully black.

She doesn't want to wake up. Pain is an old friend, but the worst kind, in that as funny as they are, you refuse to leave them with

your money purse and your fridge is always empty at the end of their visits.

But right next to pain is determination and unfortunately, Adora knows her own is forged from steel. Her lips crack open, squinting at the glint of night moons on the water lapping about her chest. Blue eyes slide about, taking in details.

She's in a river, half in and half out, nestled against the bank of a bend. It's probably an hour past midnight. Her body feels brittle—her bones feel like glass and every inch of flesh feels beaten and tenderized. It even looks like it; her stolen jumpsuit is little more than shreds and what skin she can see is still in fading shades of purple and sickly yellow. Given her body's tendency to prioritize the inside before the out, for her to look like this hours later means she must have been…

A glint beneath the water catches her eyes and she draws a sigh of relief at the sight of the sword, still clutched in her iron grip. She leans back and squints against the glare of the moons to gaze up the side of the mountain. They must have gone further up than she'd realized within the mines; she can barely see some of the signs where they were propelled from its depths and that's well over eighty feet up. No wonder she was beat up; a large fall, in conjunction with everything else her body had endured over the day, must have stretched her healing factor to its limits.

(A flash of memory: anger and despair, icy air so cold it hurt and falling, falling, *falling* —)

The scrape of metal on stone and the whir of servos makes her recently repaired heart stop.

“Finally…awake?”

Slowly, painfully, she turns her head and catches the gaze of the Beast staring back at her with inky eyes that glint in the moonlight. His flesh arm is still openly bleeding, trailing loose, twisted and useless in the water. His prosthetic isn't looking good either, dented and with panels missing. The servos seem to scream as he tries to drag himself along the bank with it, and occasionally it spasms and sparks, shocking its owner. He doesn't seem to care, continuing to stare at her with an unnerving and unwavering gaze. Even under the burble of the water and her own breathing, Adora can hear the sickly crunching, squelching and gurgling of still broken bones and torn flesh barely held together in a failing meat balloon. The bank near his head is wet with blood, bile and littered with empty and broken vials. Samples? Medicine?

For a long time the two fighters can only stare at the other, illuminated in the moonlight. Eventually, Grizzlor gives a wet cough and grins a bloody smile. “Round…three?”

“You're dying.”

“For…now. Death…is just…a…inconvenience…for us.”

“We're not alike.”

Grizzlor just began to laugh. It was exhausted and manic and terrifying and he laughed even as he cried and choked and spat and lost his grip, his prosthetic failing at last, losing his fight against the current and slowly slipping away. He laughed and laughed as he disappeared down the river and his laughter rang in Adora's ears even hours later, shattering the silence of her mind and stealing any peace she might have found in the loneliness of nature.

One final victory for Grizzlor.

They found Adora, filthy, beaten and nearly nude, trying to drag herself from the river while holding her sword.

Catra's irritation at Swift Wind and his speed evaporated and she barely noticed the dizziness she usually felt after riding the wolf as she dropped to her knees, helping the Pack Second pull Adora fully onto the bank. Her golden locks were gone and there was little more than a buzz cut's worth of hair atop her head. She could barely move her limbs and her eyes were bloodshot. Catra could see the outlines of her ribs and every square inch of her was covered in bruises, dirt and blood.

“I left you alone for a *day* !” She griped, trying to maneuver the blonde's musclebound dead weight onto Swift Wind's back. “The

hell Adora!”

Adora breathed, a weight she didn't realize was in her chest lifting. “Hey, Catra.”

“Don't ‘Hey, Catra’ me you—!”

“Cat.” Swift Wind's voice was unusually subdued. Adora's battered state seemed to have shaken him. “Let's…just go home.”

Adora stirred. “But the mission—?”

Catra wanted to yell, to scream, to curse Adora out for being half-dead and still trying to throw herself into war.

(Golden locks, stained with blood, left alone and vulnerable and dead on the concrete Fright Zone streets.)

The hybrid swallows, trying to tamp down that rush of emotion and figure out how to get some common sense through her idiot's skull.

“Boss…” Swift Wind murmured.

Something about her Second's voice and the expression on Catra's face seemed to get to her and after a long moment, any defiance in Adora's eyes sputtered out, her lids sliding shut as she went limp upon Swift Wind's back and the sword slipping to the earth as her fingers went slack.

“Let's go home,” the wolf repeated.

Catra stooped to pick up the sword. It took everything in her to secure it to her back instead of hurling it in the river. She climbed on behind her best friend's limp body, grasping onto waist and fur and Swift Wind set out, the trees blurring past them. Catra buried her face in Adora's broad and bruised shoulder and as far as anyone was concerned, any wetness that leaked from her eyes was simply due to the wind.

Their squad was the only one that could be spared. Intellectually, they knew that. They had enough trouble trying to keep control of the populace, deal with sabotage every citizen pretended they hadn't seen or known about, or deal with the new CTO's crazy experiments or abandoned tech that said citizens *also* conveniently forgot to warn them about. So as the newest and youngest, their squad was the only one that the Force Captain could spare to go track Force Captain Grizzlor's distress signal.

That didn't mean they had to like it.

As a rule few Horde-born soldiers really liked the forests or the woods. Even this not being *the* Woods, the terrain was still awful to fight in, always full of Rebels, and had shadows, wildlife, *something* behind every tree.

Still they had a job to do and the Force Captain made it easier by staying still. Or course, why he was so still became apparent soon enough.

“You think he's dead?”

“What are you asking us for, you're the medic!?”

“Of course he's dead!”

“We don't know that!”

“Then go see!”

The medic in question grimaced but complied, delicately picking her way down to the bank of the falls where Force Captain Grizzlor lay, soggy and broken. He was missing patches of fur and his prosthetic was waterlogged and useless. Open fractures weakly trailed crimson into the water and here and there awkward lumps from broken bones protruded from under the skin. His uniform was in tatters and that his badge hadn't been lost or worked at all was a miracle.

She tried to be careful but the man was heavy and she found herself puffing as she tried to lift his arm and get at his arm. "Oy, give me a hand!"

A lightning game of Robot, Shield, Gun and a grumbled curse bought one of her squadmates over to hold the arm up as she fingered the massive hybrid's pulse and opened one of his eyes to shine a light into it.

For several moments there was nothing and she was just about to call it when—

BA-BUMP

—the vein beneath her finger jumped and in the glare of the penlight and the moons, that black, inky eye slowly swiveled to stare at her.

"You sure she's fine?"

"Chill Sparkles. Give her a nap and about ten steaks and three fish and she'll be good to go by tomorrow."

Glimmer wasn't so sure. She'd never seen Adora so beaten down before. No one had. Adora, be it as herself or as She-Ra, radiated indomitability. While all but the most stubborn bruises had been healed by the time the trio had returned to Brightmoon, seeing the girl who regularly powered through enemy fire and shook off head injuries, disembowelment and the occasional amputation like they were nothing completely worn down and unconscious on the back of Swift Wind was…

She could tell it affected Catra too, despite her claims to the contrary. She didn't leave the Pack's room for one, only saying that she'd give a report tomorrow, with no mention as to whether Adora would do the same. And even her insults and snark lacked the same bite as usual

"Three fish for *Adora* , huh?"

"Duh. I eat them and then I don't have to nag her to eat because she's too worried about *me* doing it."

Honestly, that tracked. Glimmer nodded. "Alright, I'll send word down to the kitchens. Think she'll be up for visitors tomorrow? Bow and that Scorpani scout she went with really want to see her."

"We'll see. You know she's an idiot. She'll say 'yes" when she should mean 'no'."

“I can still hear you,” the idiot in question called from within the room, the fondness of her tone undermining any annoyance she tried to lace it with.

“Good.”

Glimmer wandered away with a smile as the two began to squabble, but any mirth faded as the reminder of the day's events set in.

We've got to trust each other , Bow had said, and she did. She trusted that Adora would fight for the Rebellion with all she had and beyond. She trusted that Catra, for all her snark and sass, would fight to win the war because deep down inside, she was tired of children becoming like her and Adora. She trusted that Bow would always have her back and serve as the North to her occasionally wonky moral compass. She trusted them all.

But sometimes…

She paused in the middle of the corridor, gazing up at the ever immaculate mural of her father. One hand touched its painted hand, the closest she would ever get to holding him again.

The other, unbidden, drifted to her pocket and the tube within. It seemed to burn with promise and betrayal.

…sometimes trust wasn't enough.

Adora gnawed slowly on her favorite chew toy, letting the scent and taste of the herbal bundle within slowly soothe her. It feels good, especially after the day she's had and especially because her last bundle of smokes was little more than ash in a random mine in Dryl now.

Of course, the drug and the toy only provide so much distraction from the pointed silence. “I underestimated him,” she says toward her simmering best friend. “I won't again.”

“You won't,” Catra intones lowly, “because you won't be fighting him again without backup, if at all. Right?”

Adora remains silent, and Catra grabs her jaw and turns her still disconcertingly light head to face her feline Commander, her claws pricking the blonde's skin in her agitation. “Promise me, Adora.”

“...I can't.”

Mismatched eyes widened then narrowed in hurt, anger and betrayal. Adora can't bear to look as Catra roughly releases her face and storms out of the room without a word.

Faolin licks her face and the pack cuddles close because they can feel the turmoil that fails to express. They can sense the rage that boils through her veins at the memory of the way Grizzlor's voice curled around Catra's description with a cruel glee and sick fascination. And they can sense her resolve and grief that she cannot give her word, cannot say the words because she will fight a thousand Grizzlors and burn and break and die a thousand times before she lets a single filthy claw touch her Catra.

Still…she's not strong enough. Not skilled enough. Grizzlor's nickname was demeaning but still true—bitter, yes, but true. In skill, in martial prowess, she was still just a Cadet. But she would train. She would grow. And one day, she'd be able to make and keep that promise because she'll have torn out the threat root and stem.

Her eyes gaze out the open window, drawn to the East and the treetops of the Whispering Woods, to the hidden Castle within its depth.

Her training, it seemed, was long overdue.

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